

Week 1 — Customer-Centric Foundations

"A Technical Product Manager who cannot describe the customer's problem in the customer's own words is not yet managing a product."

Week 1 grounds the Academy in the practice that separates TPMs from feature-delivery managers: **relentless customer understanding**. Every subsequent week — metrics, PRDs, architecture, stakeholder negotiation, delivery — loses anchoring without this foundation.

This week is the most group-oriented of the entire academy. Participants form **cohort triads** on Day 1 that persist through the end of Week 3 (carrying them into the mini-capstone).

Learning outcomes

By Friday afternoon, each participant can:

1. Prompt a generative AI tool using structured patterns (role, context, constraints, format) to accelerate PM research — and know when *not* to trust the output.
2. Draft an Amazon-style PR/FAQ for a product idea and defend it against peer challenge.
3. Construct, validate, and stress-test a user persona from qualitative inputs — distinguishing observed behavior from assumed behavior.
4. Elicit and prioritize pain points using severity × frequency × addressability scoring.
5. Produce a **data-driven problem statement** that a reasonable engineering lead would accept as an input to scoping.

Daily map

DAY	TOPIC	KEY ARTIFACT PRODUCED
1	AI fundamentals & prompting for PMs	Prompt pattern library (triad)
2	Working Backwards framework	PR/FAQ draft (triad)
3	Building & validating user personas	Validated persona sheet (triad)
4	Identifying pain points	Ranked pain-point map (triad)
5	Data-driven problem framing	Problem statement + evidence brief (triad, presented)

Each day's artifact is an input to the next. Friday readouts preview the muscles used in the Week 3 mini-capstone.

Daily cadence (applies to every day of the week)

CLOCK	BLOCK	MIX
09:00 – 09:15	Opening & objectives	Instructor
09:15 – 10:30	Teaching Block 1 + Activity 1	~25 min teach / 50 min group
10:30 – 10:45	Break	
10:45 – 12:00	Teaching Block 2 + Activity 2	~25 min teach / 50 min group
12:00 – 13:00	Lunch	
13:00 – 14:15	Teaching Block 3 + Activity 3	~25 min teach / 50 min group
14:15 – 14:30	Break	
14:30 – 16:00	Teaching Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts + Wrap	~25 min teach / 45 min group / 20 min readout

Group composition: triads (3 participants) are the default. Every activity brief calls out when the format is pair, triad, quartet, or full-room.

Facilitator pre-flight checklist

- ☐ Confirm every participant has access to a generative AI tool (ChatGPT, Claude, or equivalent) before Day 1 starts.
- ☐ Pre-print or share digitally: the **Persona Validation Canvas** (Day 3), **Pain-Point Severity Matrix** (Day 4), and **Problem Statement Template** (Day 5).
- ☐ Form cohort triads by the end of Day 1 morning; triads persist through Week 3.
- ☐ Prepare the **running case study** — the academy uses a shared reference product "*FieldPulse*", a mobile-first dispatch tool for field service technicians. This appears in every day's examples; read the FieldPulse brief in `day-01-ai-fundamentals.md` before facilitating.
- ☐ Review the Week 1 capstone readout rubric (end of this file).

Materials referenced across the week

- `day-01-ai-fundamentals.md` — Prompt pattern library, FieldPulse case brief
- `day-02-working-backwards.md` — PR/FAQ template, 5 customer questions worksheet
- `day-03-personas.md` — Persona Validation Canvas, interview script cards
- `day-04-pain-points.md` — Severity × Frequency × Addressability matrix
- `day-05-problem-framing.md` — Problem statement template, evidence tier guide

Week 1 readout rubric (Friday afternoon)

Each triad presents a **10-minute integrated artifact**: persona → top 3 pain points → problem statement. Peer and instructor score on:

DIMENSION	WEIGHT	WHAT "EXEMPLARY" LOOKS LIKE
Customer authenticity	25%	Persona grounded in observed behavior, not assumption; validation evidence named
Pain specificity	25%	Pains are verbs ("cannot reconcile end-of-day inventory"), not categories ("bad UX")
Evidence quality	20%	Every claim tagged with evidence tier (observed / reported / inferred / AI-generated)
Problem statement clarity	20%	A senior engineer could scope from it without a clarifying call
AI-use transparency	10%	Where AI was used, the prompt and validation step are disclosed

Bridge to Week 2

Week 2 opens by converting each triad's problem statement into **strategic design moves and metrics** — the North Star, operational signals, and customer-journey map that will turn Week 1's understanding into something measurable.